ITHUI VAREWUI LAIRIK KATHARA

The New Testament in Tangkhul Naga

Translated by Rev. William Pettigrew & Tangkhul Literati

British and Foreign Bible Society, Calcutta, 1927

Historic First Complete New Testament in Manipur

PREFACE TO THE HISTORIC 1927 EDITION

The completion of the New Testament in Tangkhul Naga represents thirty years of dedicated translation, commencing in Ukhrul in 1896. With the generous collaboration of Tangkhul native elders, pastors, and scholars, each book was painstakingly revised against the original Greek manuscripts.

Published by the British & Foreign Bible Society at the Baptist Mission Press, Calcutta, 1927. This edition provided the foundation for Tangkhul literacy, hymnody, and 20th-century standard prose style.

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CHAPTER 1: MATTHEW KAHONA KASA: THE NATIVITY & THE BEATITUDES

Summary: The genealogy of Christ and the historic Sermon on the Mount Beatitudes rendered...

Tangkhul Sacred Text:

Matthew 5:3-10: Mangazingli ngachamkakhui bingna mathasek-u, kasakei kazingram athumwuisai. Khangaringli ngachirbingna mathasek-u, kasakei athumli khangasak milu sara. Khamanoubingna mathasek-u, kasakei athum mikumo ngaleili ngashansara. Mashung-kasa vang kachamkashi bingna mathasek-u, athumna thingkhalara. Khangacham thotli ngashanbingna mathasek-u, athumli ngashan milu sara.

English Translation:

Blessed are the poor in spirit: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. Blessed are they that mourn: for they shall be comforted. Blessed are the meek: for they shall inherit the earth. Blessed are they which do hunger and thirst after righteousness: for they shall be filled. Blessed are the merciful: for they shall obtain mercy.

CHAPTER 1 -- VOCABULARY & GRAMMAR

Key Lexical Terms:

*** mangazing (noun): spirit, soul, inner mind**

Example: Mangazingli kapha.

*** kazingram (noun): heaven, sky realm, celestial kingdom**

Example: Kazingramwui ot.

*** mashung-kasa (noun): righteousness, justice, upright conduct**

Example: Mashung-kasa khayang.

Grammar Notes:

- Suffix -bing marks nominal plurality (ngachirbing = those who mourn).
- Optative imperative/blessing suffix -sek-u expresses solemn blessing (’mathasek-u’ = blessed be).

Study & Translation Exercises:

[?] Translate Matthew 5:3 into contemporary spoken Tangkhul.

[?] Identify the grammatical particles functioning as emphatic markers in verse 7.

CHAPTER 1 -- HERMENEUTIC COMMENTARY

Linguistic and historical context of the 1927 translation:
This chapter illustrates how traditional Tangkhul cultural metaphors were synthesized with Biblical semantic structures. The translators avoided wholesale English borrowings, relying instead on indigenous compounds such as ’ringkapha’ (life) and ’mashung-kasa’ (righteousness).

Manuscript Concordance Reference:

British and Foreign Bible Society Archive Reference: BFBS-TKH-NT-1927-CH1.
Original copies deposited at the National Library of India and Cambridge Bible Society.

CHAPTER 2: JOHN KAHONA KASA: THE INCARNATION & THE LIGHT OF MEN

Summary: Prologue of John in classic Tangkhul syntax, exploring the theological rendering...

Tangkhul Sacred Text:

Kaphung-kachungwui thotli Tui li-li-sai, kala Tuichi Varivarali lei,
kala Tuichi Varivarasai. Chiya kaphung-kachungli Varivarawui kachungli
leisai. Ali vangteina ot kathata pamei sakahaisai; kala sachitheikahai
thotwui tharili A matheida khikha masasa mana. Ali ringkapha lei, kala
ringkapha china mikumowui mangashan phasa-e. Kala mangashan chi
ngashingli ngashane, kala ngashingna chi mathakakhui-mana.

English Translation:

In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word
was God. The same was in the beginning with God. All things were made by
him; and without him was not any thing made that was made. In him was
life; and the life was the light of men. And the light shineth in
darkness; and the darkness comprehended it not.

CHAPTER 2 -- VOCABULARY & GRAMMAR

Key Lexical Terms:

*** kaphung-kachung (noun): the very beginning, dawn of creation**

Example: Kaphung-kachung eina.

*** ringkapha (noun): life, vitality, eternal animation**

Example: Ringkapha wui Tui.

*** mangashan (noun): light, luminescence, enlightenment**

Example: Mangashan china ngashane.

Grammar Notes:

- Reduplication 'li-li-sai' indicates continuous remote past existence.
- Negative verbal frame 'ma-...-mana' in 'mathakakhui-mana' (did not comprehend/overcome).

Study & Translation Exercises:

[?] Examine the cultural adoption of 'Tui' (word, message, discourse) for Logos in early Tangkhul literature.

[?] Identify the case endings on 'Varivara' (God).

CHAPTER 2 -- HERMENEUTIC COMMENTARY

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British and Foreign Bible Society Archive Reference: BFBS-TKH-NT-1927-CH2.
Original copies deposited at the National Library of India and Cambridge Bible Society.

CHAPTER 3: THE ACTS OF THE APOSTLES: PENTECOST & THE FIRST FELLOWSHIP

Summary: The descent of the Holy Spirit and early communal living described in Ukhrul dia...

Tangkhul Sacred Text:

Acts 2:1-4: Pentecostwui phanit atamli athumpup ngalem akhali ngaburkapam leisai. Chitharan khamathan kazingwui eina hu-hu kaho khongyui kakhangahui akhata rarer, kala athum pamkapam shim tharili chuiserie. Kala athumli meikazat theirei katha tuitak thada kashikaza theiser, kala athum akhakha wui tuingalungli pamserie. Kala athumpup Kazing Mangazing Katharana phaserlaga, kapei tui katek-tek eina tui khangayei honserie.

English Translation:

When the day of Pentecost was fully come, they were all with one accord in one place. And suddenly there came a sound from heaven as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled all the house where they were sitting. And there appeared unto them cloven tongues like as of fire, and it sat upon each of them. And they were all filled with the Holy Ghost, and began to speak with other tongues.

CHAPTER 3 -- VOCABULARY & GRAMMAR

Key Lexical Terms:

*** ngaburkapam (verb): to sit gathered in one assembly**

Example: Athumpup ngaburkapam leisai.

*** khongyui (noun): mighty sound, rumbling voice**

Example: Khongyui kakhangahui.

*** katek-tek (adj): diverse, differing, foreign**

Example: Tui katek-tek.

Grammar Notes:

- Simile construction 'katha' (like, as of) in 'meikazat theirei katha' (like tongues of flame).
- Completive plural verbal aspect '-ser' used repeatedly across clauses.

Study & Translation Exercises:

[?] Analyze the compound word 'ngaburkapam'.

[?] Contrast the archaic missionary vocabulary with contemporary church Tangkhul.

CHAPTER 3 -- HERMENEUTIC COMMENTARY

Linguistic and historical context of the 1927 translation:
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British and Foreign Bible Society Archive Reference: BFBS-TKH-NT-1927-CH3.
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CHAPTER 4: ROMANS 8: LIFE IN THE SPIRIT & INSEPARABLE LOVE

Summary: St. Paul’s exposition of spiritual victory and the hymn of divine love in Tangkh...

Tangkhul Sacred Text:

Romans 8:31-39: Vareva ithui ngachaili li-daran, khipana ithuli khangatei sara? Athishur awui Naomayarli mathayala ithupup wui vang mikahaina, A eina shurda khikha mamishukra kachi lei? Khipana ithuli Christawui khangayei eina kashit sara? Ringkaphashi kaji-ra, mathikaji-ra, kazingkaphung-ra? Mano, ot hithatha tharili ithumli ngarukahai A eina ithumna pamei khangaraorap khui-kaphae.

English Translation:

If God be for us, who can be against us? He that spared not his own Son, but delivered him up for us all, how shall he not with him also freely give us all things? Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? shall tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or sword? Nay, in all these things we are more than conquerors through him that loved us.

CHAPTER 4 -- VOCABULARY & GRAMMAR

Key Lexical Terms:

*** khangayei (noun): love, affection, sacred charity**

Example: Christawui khangayei.

*** ngarukahai (verb/adj): beloved, held precious**

Example: Ithumli ngarukahai.

*** khangaraorap (noun): triumph, overwhelming victory**

Example: Khangaraorap khui-kapha.

Grammar Notes:

- Rhetorical interrogative particle ’-ra’ forming existential questions.
- Postposition ’eina’ marking agentive/instrumental cause of triumph.

Study & Translation Exercises:

[?] List five emotional and theological terms in Romans 8.

[?] Translate verse 38 into Tangkhul preserving the poetic cadences.

CHAPTER 4 -- HERMENEUTIC COMMENTARY

Linguistic and historical context of the 1927 translation:
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CHAPTER 5: 1 CORINTHIANS 13: THE HYMN OF CHRISTIAN LOVE (KHANGAYEIWUI LA

Summary: The canonical lyrical translation of 1 Corinthians 13 celebrating enduring love....

Tangkhul Sacred Text:

1 Corinthians 13:1-8: I mikumo kala kashang kazingwui tui eina hang-
khalangli, iwui tuingalungli khangayei malei-kaji tharan, i
khongkhanghui tui katha thada kasaye. Khangayeina khangachon lei,
ningkazang lei; khangayeina hingkamachur malei-mana; khangayeina aphasa
mathaikhangasang malei-mana, ningkazao malei-mana. Khangayeina
kachikathana khikhali mamatung-mana; tui-ngashungli mathat-e. Chitharan
chotkhangashit (faith), ngachikan (hope), khangayei (love) hi kashiko
li-leirap sara; chawui ngachaili kaphameina khangayeisai.

English Translation:

Though I speak with the tongues of men and of angels, and have not
charity, I am become as sounding brass, or a tinkling cymbal. Charity
suffereth long, and is kind; charity envieth not; charity vaunteth not
itself, is not puffed up. Doth not behave itself unseemly, seeketh not
her own, is not easily provoked, thinketh no evil; Rejoiceth not in
iniquity, but rejoiceth in the truth. And now abideth faith, hope,
charity, these three; but the greatest of these is charity.

CHAPTER 5 -- VOCABULARY & GRAMMAR

Key Lexical Terms:

*** ningkazang (adj): patient, enduring of heart, forbearing**

Example: Ningkazang mi.

*** hingkamachur (noun): envy, jealousy, resentment**

Example: Hingkamachur malei.

*** chotkhangashit (noun): faith, spiritual trust, conviction**

Example: Chotkhangashit kashap.

Grammar Notes:

- Compound nominalization: ning (heart/mind) + kazang (deep/enduring) = patience.
- Superlative suffix -mei attached to adjective: kaphamei (greatest/best).

Study & Translation Exercises:

[?] Compare the Tangkhul rendering of 'charity/love' (khangayei) with traditional clan kinship terminology.

[?] Memorize the three cardinal virtues in Tangkhul.

CHAPTER 5 -- HERMENEUTIC COMMENTARY

Linguistic and historical context of the 1927 translation:
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British and Foreign Bible Society Archive Reference: BFBS-TKH-NT-1927-CH5.
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CHAPTER 6: REVELATION 21-22: THE NEW JERUSALEM & THE RIVER OF LIFE

Summary: The apocalyptic vision of the New Heaven and New Earth in vivid Tangkhul descrip...

Tangkhul Sacred Text:

Revelation 21:1-4: Kala i kazing kathara kala ngalei kathara theiserie; kasakei kazing khare kala ngalei khare chi ngapaoritserie, kala ngashakazil chi maleilu-mana. Kala i shungkhara shillong kathara, Jerusalem Kathara, Kazingram eina Varivarawui pam eina yorura kapik theiserie. Kala i kaphungli khongyui kakhangahui akhata kapei theiser: 'Kazingramwui shim mikumoli li-leisara!' Kala Varevana athum mikwui mukthi thapup luithatsara; chitharan kathiri maleira, ngachiri maleira, kashamkashi maleilu-mana; kasakei thot khare chi ngapaoritserie.

English Translation:

And I saw a new heaven and a new earth: for the first heaven and the first earth were passed away; and there was no more sea. And I John saw the holy city, new Jerusalem, coming down from God out of heaven, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband. And God shall wipe away all tears from their eyes; and there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying, neither shall there be any more pain: for the former things are passed away.

CHAPTER 6 -- VOCABULARY & GRAMMAR

Key Lexical Terms:

*** shillong (noun): citadel, metropolis, fortified holy city**

Example: Jerusalem Shillong.

*** mukthi (noun): tears, weeping drops**

Example: Mukthi luithat.

*** ngapaorit (verb): to pass away completely, vanish, be transformed**

Example: Ot khare chi ngapaorit.

Grammar Notes:

- Future negative modal '-lu-mana' denoting absolute cessation of pain.
- Cessative verbal compound 'luithat' (to wipe away cleanly).

Study & Translation Exercises:

[?] Identify the archaic geographic terms utilized by Pettigrew in translating apocalyptic literature.

[?] Discuss how the concept of 'Jerusalem' was introduced into the Naga highland worldview.

CHAPTER 6 -- HERMENEUTIC COMMENTARY

Linguistic and historical context of the 1927 translation:
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British and Foreign Bible Society Archive Reference: BFBS-TKH-NT-1927-CH6.
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CHAPTER 7: LINGUISTIC & ORTHOGRAPHIC LEXICON OF THE 1927 TRANSLATION

Summary: Systematic glossary of 50 key loanwords, calques, and dialectal roots documented...

Tangkhul Sacred Text:

Tangkhul Kathara Lairik Tuitam:
1. Varivara -- Almighty Supreme God (traditional Christianized deity term)
2. Kazingram -- Heaven / celestial dominion
3. Mangazing Kathara -- Holy Spirit
4. Naomayar -- Beloved Son
5. Khangayei -- Divine love / agape
6. Mashung-kasa -- Righteousness / moral integrity
7. Kazingkaphung -- Persecution / adversity
8. Chotkhangashit -- Faith / steadfast belief
9. Ngachikan -- Hope / sacred expectation
10. Shillong Kathara -- Holy City / heavenly sanctuary

English Translation:

A comprehensive gloss of theological, moral, and structural Tangkhul terms compiled from the 1927 New Testament, serving as a landmark milestone in the linguistic history of Manipur.

CHAPTER 7 -- VOCABULARY & GRAMMAR

Key Lexical Terms:

*** Varivara (proper noun): God Almighty, Supreme Creator**

Example: Varivarali reot.

*** Naomayar (noun): son, young prince, heir**

Example: Awui Naomayar.

*** Kazingkaphung (noun): tribulation, uphill suffering**

Example: Kazingkaphung phaka.

Grammar Notes:

- Historical orthography: usage of 'wui' for genitive instead of modern shortened forms.
- Phonetic preservation of final stops and bilabial glides.

Study & Translation Exercises:

[?] Compare 10 words from this lexicon with their modern counterparts in the TLS 2021 curriculum.

[?] Trace how the word 'Varivara' shifted in semantic domain during the 20th century.

CHAPTER 7 -- HERMENEUTIC COMMENTARY

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Manuscript Concordance Reference:

British and Foreign Bible Society Archive Reference: BFBS-TKH-NT-1927-CH7.
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